design in 2003, which was approved in 2006. The first prototype took flight in March 2010, followed by extensive testing and refinements which made it battle-ready for high-altitude warfare.

The chopper's twin 'Shakti' engines, derived from French co-developer Safran's Ardiden turboshaft engine, have been extensively tested in precisely those conditions in Siachen—the world's highest battlefield—which validated its operational capabilities. At 1,384 hp each, the twin engines enable it to take off and land at altitudes above 5,000 metres with a substantial payload. That includes a formidable weapons suite: a 20mm nose gun, 70mm rocket pods, and the ability to deploy India's Dhruvastra anti-tank guided missiles and France's Mistral-2 air-to-air missiles. Among attack helicopters, it is one of only three—alongside China's Z-10 and Turkey's T129 ATAK—that claim high-altitude capabilities. However, both the Z-10 and T129 have struggled with underpowered engines, raising

A FIERCE PUSH

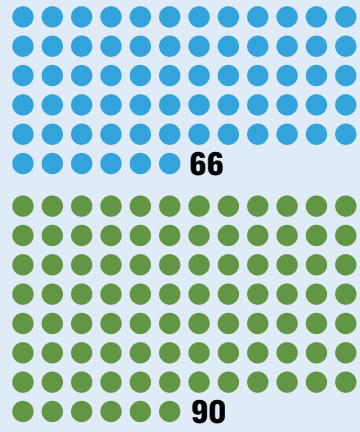
Prachand is a light combat helicopter developed by HAL, capable of self-protection and delivering a wide variety of ammunition to the field quickly, especially in high-altitude operations



CHOPPERS IN SERVICE 15



ORDER PLACED FOR 156



IAF Indian Army

KEY FEATURES

WEIGHT	MAXIMUM SPEED
5.8 TONNE	288 KMPH
COMBAT RADIUS	**OPERATIONAL CEILING**
500 KM	5,490 METRE

ARMS AND AMMUNITION

Chin-mounted 20mm turret twin-barrel gun, 70mm rocket pods, air-to-air missiles and cluster bombs

HAL PLANS TO DELIVER THE FIRST BATCH OF PRACHAND HELICOPTERS BY MID-2028, FOLLOWED BY AROUND 30 ANNUALLY, COMPLETING THE ORDER BY MID-2033

concerns about their performance at extreme elevations. The Prachand, in contrast, has repeatedly proven its capabilities in Himalayan trials.

Designed for swift and aggressive operations, with an armoured cockpit ensuring crew protection, the Prachand boasts a top speed of 288 kmph and a combat radius of 500 km. Its maximum takeoff weight of 5.8 tonnes—as against, say, the Apache's 10.4 tonnes—is what allows it that agility. That also makes it versatile across multiple roles, from counter-insurgency and urban warfare to escorting special forces and neutralising enemy air defences.

The contract, finalised on March 28, includes 66 helicopters for the IAF and 90 for the army, with deliveries scheduled to begin by mid-2028. HAL plans to deliver the first batch by then, followed by around 30 helicopters annually, completing the order by mid-2033. The deal aims to achieve overall 65 per cent indigenous components in the Prachand. This will involve over 250 domestic companies, mostly MSMEs, and will generate over 8,500 direct and indirect jobs, according to the MoD. Innovations like the rotor damper system, developed by Bengaluru-based TimeTooth Technologies in 2024, have already reduced reliance on foreign components.

In fact, it's the incorporation of this aspect of robust self-reliance while meeting military needs that makes the Prachand stand out. It synergises the two, rather than sacrifice one for the other. That's why Union defence minister Rajnath Singh can hail the Prachand as a "formidable machine" that will provide India's armed forces with a crucial combat edge. It does indeed tick many boxes that its predecessors could not.

India's attack helicopter fleet is undergoing a transformation as the ageing Russian Mi-25 and Mi-35 helicopters, long the backbone of India's combat rotorcraft, are being phased out. They will be replaced by a mix of Prachand and Boeing AH-64E Apaches. While the Apache, considered the world's premier multi-role attack helicopter, has been in service with the